INFANTRY WEAPONS

At the start of World War I most British infantrymen fought with nothing more than rifle and bayonet, backed up by a scattering of heavy machine-guns. Trench weaponry gradually improved and diversified. Grenades, used by the Germans from the start of the war, were soon adopted by the British. The infantry also acquired its own artillery in the form of the trench mortar. Trench raiding spawned equipment that ranged from wire cutters to primitive weapons for hand-to-hand fighting.

Protected fore sight
Cleaning rod
Single-edged blade

Firing pin
Safety lever, released as grenade left the cup
Detachable base plate

NO. 36 GRENADE

Impact fuse
Fragmentation casing
Arming mechanism
Clip to attach grenade to rifle muzzle
Rod – inserted into rifle barrel

Clips to attach discharger to rifle muzzle

DISCHARGER CUP

Rifle grenades
Various devices were used to deliver grenades into the opposing trenches. This version of the No. 36 model of the Mills bomb could be fitted into a discharger cup attached to the rifle. A blank was fired, which struck the base of the grenade and activated it. The fuse was set for a longer time than on a normal hand grenade. A special blank was also used to fire the Hales No. 3 "stick" grenade. This had a longer range, but had a more complicated and less reliable device for arming the grenade in flight.

Ring that had to be pulled to activate grenade
Safety lever – when released, it activated five-second fuse
Impact fuse

MILLS BOMB

Hand grenades
The British army experimented with many designs for hand grenades, some with impact fuses, others with time fuses. The early No. 1 grenade had a tail of streamers designed to ensure that the head of the grenade hit the ground first. In the end grenades with time fuses proved more successful and from 1916 one of the most widely used was the classic pineapple-shaped Mills bomb, which continued in use through World War II.

NO. 1 GRENADE

Safety ring – removed before loading bomb in mortar
Fuse that detonated on impact however the bomb landed

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